



WHALE CLASS

Circle Time Guide

Everything you need, one page per day.

Week 5 · Five Food Groups on My Plate

5–9 October 2026 · 13 minutes a day · ages 2.5–6, English learners

First week back after 国庆 · 寒露 (Cold Dew) falls on Thursday 8 October

🖨️ Print · laminate · ring-bind · hold this all week

FIVE WORDS THEY'LL OWN BY FRIDAY

fruit

vegetable

grain

milk

egg

Littles (2.5–3) — one word + a gesture is a win: “Fruit!” (a big bite out of an invisible apple), “Milk!” (drink from a cup, then wipe a milk moustache), “Egg!” (crack it on the edge of your hand).

Bigs (4–6) — sentence frames: “An apple is a fruit.” · “Corn is a grain.” · “Milk is a dairy food.” · “I can ____!”

THE 13-MINUTE FLOW, EVERY DAY

2 MIN Magic Box hook — chant, shake, sniff, dramatic peek, the day's real food.

4 MIN Teach — the day's group, real food in your hands, into its basket. Get it wrong once on purpose.

3 MIN Song — chorus → today's new verse → chorus.

3 MIN Game — one named game, tied to the day's word.

1 MIN Close — whisper → normal → SHOUT.

IN THE MAGIC BOX, DAY BY DAY

Mon a basket of real fruit — apple, banana, grapes · **Tue** a carrot with its leaves on + fresh bean pods (毛豆)
 · **Wed** a jar of rice, a whole corn cob, a slice of bread · **Thu** a cup of milk, a piece of cheese, and a dewy leaf from the garden for 寒露 · **Fri** an egg, a dish of nuts, and every prop from the week, built into the pyramid.

THE WEEK'S CLOSE

Everyone: “Fruit... vegetable... grain... milk... EGG! FIVE FOOD GROUPS!”

THEME SHELF · FOUR TRAYS

- 1 · 食物分类卡 food-group sorting — five labelled baskets, picture cards, a colour dot per group on the back.
- 2 · The food pyramid mat — cards go on their layer; the printed outlines are the control.
- 3 · Bean shelling and rice spooning — real pods, a bowl, a shell dish, a jar and a small spoon.
- 4 · 寒露节气三段卡 Cold Dew three-part cards + the dew glass and a magnifying glass.

CHINESE ANGLE

汉字 beside the day's basket: 果 · 菜 · 米 · 奶 · 蛋. The 寒露 童谣, chanted on Thursday with the dew leaf in hand: 寒露到，露水凉；添衣裳，喝热汤。

FRIDAY'S DARK PHONICS SOUND

m — lips together, hum, finger on the nose: milk, meat, mango, map, mum, moon. *mmm, muddy monkey!*

Welcome Back — Fruit!

Today's words: fruit (*first day back after 国庆*)

Grab: the Magic Box with a small basket of **real fruit** inside — one apple, one banana, a little bunch of grapes; five empty baskets or bowls for the five groups, lined up on the mat; the 汉字 card 果.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

A whole week apart. Before the box, one fast lap of the circle — ten seconds a child, no more:

Teacher: “Where did the holiday take you?” (*Littles get one word and a big nod — “Grandma!” “Park!” — and that is plenty*)

Now the box. Hold it up. It smells of something.

Everyone: “What’s in the box? What’s in the box?”

Teacher: “The Magic Box went on holiday too. Look what it brought back!” (*lift out the apple, hold it under your nose, close your eyes*)

Pass the apple round to be sniffed, one child at a time. **“Fruit!”**

4 MIN TEACH · FRUIT

Hold each fruit up, name it, take one enormous noisy pretend bite, then drop it into the **fruit** basket.

An apple — a **fruit!** (*big bite, loud crunch*)

A banana — a **fruit!** (*peel it in the air, then bite*)

Grapes — a **fruit!** (*pop them one after another, quick quick quick*)

All in the fruit basket! (*both hands, in it goes*)

Littles say the one word **“Fruit!”** with the giant bite. Bigs say the frame: **“An apple is a fruit.”**

Lay the 汉字 card 果 beside the basket and say it once, together: 果 — fruit.

Teacher fails: put the banana in the **milk** basket — “It’s yellowy-white... it must be milk!” Hold it there and look pleased. Wait. The correction shout is the loudest English of the day.

3 MIN GAME · FRUIT BASKET PASS

“One, two, three — eyes on me!” Everyone in a circle. One real fruit starts going round.

Teacher: “Smell it... name it... pass it on!”

Each child takes it in two hands, sniffs it, says **“Fruit!”** — Bigs say **“An apple is a fruit.”** — and passes it on.

Second lap: send the banana the other way at the same time, so two fruits cross. Third lap: add the grapes. Three fruits chasing each other round a circle of three-year-olds is the whole game.

A child who won’t speak will still **sniff** and pass. Say the word for them, warmly, and keep it moving.

1 MIN CLOSE

Sitting, invisible apple in both hands. Whisper → normal → shout:

Everyone: “Fruit... fruit... FRUIT!” (*one huge bite on the shout*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *The Very Hungry Caterpillar* (Eric Carle) — only the fruit pages. Count them and name them together.

3 MIN · Today's song moment — chorus → **Monday's verse** → chorus.

“An apple is a fruit, so sweet and round, / crunch, crunch, crunch — what a happy sound!” (*round arms; three enormous bites*)

Vegetables from the Ground

Today's words: vegetable (*fruit comes back every day*)

Grab: a carrot with its leaves still on; a handful of fresh **bean pods** (毛豆); a bowl for the beans and a little dish for the empty shells; the five baskets; the 汉字 card 菜.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

Box chant. Shake it — a dry rattle, like something in a shell.

Everyone: "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Reach in and take hold of the carrot **by its leaves**. Pull it out very slowly, grunting, like it is stuck in the ground.

Teacher: "Ohhh... it was in the GROUND. Look at its hair!" (*swing the leafy top*)

Everyone pulls their own imaginary carrot out of the carpet. **"Vegetable!"**

4 MIN TEACH · VEGETABLE

A carrot grows **down**, in the dark under the ground. Beans grow **up**, on a plant in the sun. Everyone becomes a carrot: crouch tiny, leaves (hands) on top of your head — you go round and "pull" each child up by their leaves.

A carrot grows down, down, down... (*crouch smaller and smaller, hands on head like leaves*)

Pull it **UP!** (*shoot up straight*)

A bean grows up on a plant, (*hands climbing over each other*)

Pop the pod — one, two, three! (*two thumbs press an imaginary pod open*)

Little ones say **"Vegetable!"** and pull. Bigs say **"A carrot is a vegetable."** Both go in the **vegetable** basket, and the 汉字 card 菜 goes down beside it.

Teacher fails: hold the carrot up by its leaves and announce, "This one grew on a TREE — right up at the very top." Point at the ceiling. Nod. Wait for the roar.

3 MIN GAME · POD THE BEANS

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" The bowl in the middle, the little shell dish beside it. One real pod each.

Teacher: "Two thumbs... press... POP!" (*open one pod slowly so they all see the beans in a row*)

Each child presses their pod open and drops the beans in the bowl one at a time while the whole class counts them in: **"One... two... three!"** The empty shell goes in the shell dish, not the floor.

Go round twice if there are pods enough. Bigs count in English and then tell you the total.

Everything you just used goes straight onto the theme shelf as Tray 3 — same bowl, same dish, same beans, all week.

1 MIN CLOSE

Crouched down for the first word, up on the last. Whisper → normal → shout:

Everyone: "Fruit... VEGETABLE!" (*pull the carrot up out of the carpet on the shout*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *Oliver's Vegetables* (Vivian French) — name every vegetable on the page and pull each one up with him.

3 MIN · Today's song moment — chorus → **Tuesday's verse** → chorus.

"A carrot and a bean grow in the ground, / pull them up — look what I found!" (*crouch low, hands flat on the floor; pull up hard and show your empty hands*)

Grains — Rice, Corn, Bread

Today's words: grain (*fruit · vegetable come back*)

Grab: a jar of **rice** with a lid, a whole **corn cob**, a slice of **bread**; a second empty jar and a small spoon; the grain cards for the hunt (print pack page 14); the 汉字 card 米.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

Box chant. Shake it — a long soft hiss, like rain on a window. Do it again. Let them guess.

Everyone: “What’s in the box? What’s in the box?”

Teacher: “Listen... is it rain?” (*shake it beside one child’s ear, then the next, then the next*) “It is RICE.”

Out comes the jar. Everyone shakes their own imaginary jar. **“Grain!”**

4 MIN TEACH · GRAIN

Three grains, side by side on the mat: the rice jar, the corn cob, the slice of bread. Bread is a grain too — tell that story in three claps: **seed** → **flour** → **bread**.

Rice — a **grain!** (*shake the jar*)

Corn — a **grain!** (*hold the cob up like a trumpet and blow it*)

Bread — a **grain!** (*two flat hands, one slice*)

All in the grain basket! (*in they go, one at a time*)

Littles say **“Grain!”** and shake. Bigs say **“Corn is a grain.”** The 汉字 card 米 goes down beside the basket.

Teacher fails: drop the corn cob into the **fruit** basket — “It’s yellow and it’s sweet, so it must be a fruit!” Dust off your hands, satisfied. Wait.

3 MIN GAME · GRAIN HUNT

Before circle, hide the grain cards — rice, corn, bread, noodles — round the room, low down where they can see them.

Teacher: “One, two, three — eyes on me! The grains have run away. Ready... GO!”

They hunt. Every card found comes straight back to the mat, and the finder holds it up and names it before it goes into the **grain** basket: **“Rice!”** Bigs: **“Rice is a grain.”**

Hide them again for a second, faster round, and let a Big do the hiding while the rest cover their eyes.

Count the cards out loud before you hide them and count them back in at the end — that is the control of error, and it stops one card living under the bookshelf until Christmas.

1 MIN CLOSE

Three fingers up, one per word. Whisper → normal → shout:

Everyone: “Fruit... vegetable... GRAIN!” (*one big shake of the rice jar on the shout*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *Bread, Bread, Bread* (Ann Morris) — bread from all over the world. Just point and say “Grain!” on every page.

3 MIN · Today’s song moment — chorus → **Wednesday’s verse** → chorus.

“Rice and corn and a slice of bread, / grains, grains, grains — that’s what I said!” (*shake · trumpet · flat hands; three shakes, point at yourself*)

Milk, Cheese and Cold Dew

Today's words: milk (and 寒露 — Cold Dew is today)

Grab: a cup of milk (and a spare), a piece of cheese; a leaf with real dew on it picked from the garden this morning; a glass of very cold water and a magnifying glass; an ice pack for the bottom of the box; the 汉字 card 奶.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

The box is **cold** today — an ice pack has been sitting in the bottom of it. Let them all touch the outside first.

Everyone: “What's in the box? What's in the box?”

Teacher: “Cold! The box is COLD today.” (*lift out the dew leaf on a flat palm*) “Look — water on a leaf. This is 寒露 — Cold Dew.”

One finger each, one drop each, round the circle. Then out comes the milk. **“Milk!”**

4 MIN TEACH · MILK

Pour the milk. Drink it in one long theatrical glug. Wipe the moustache off with the back of your hand. Everyone copies with an invisible cup. Then hold up the cheese: **cheese is made from milk** — same family, same basket.

Milk in my cup — (*pour, then drink*)

Cheese on my plate — (*one flat slice on the palm*)

Drink it all up... (*long glug, then the moustache wipe*)

STRONG bones! (*everyone squeezes their own arm*)

Littles say **“Milk!”** and wipe the moustache. Bigs say **“Milk is a dairy food.”** The 汉字 card 奶 goes beside the basket.

Now the 童谣, chanted twice with the dew leaf held up in front of you: 寒露到，露水凉；添衣裳，喝热汤。 (*Cold Dew comes, the dew is cold; put on warm clothes, drink hot soup.*)

Teacher fails: hold up the cheese and say, “This one grew on a tree. I picked it myself.” Look at it fondly. Let them shout you down twice before you give in.

3 MIN GAME · RUN IT TO THE GROUP

Five hoops (or five sheets of paper) on the floor, well apart, with a food-group basket sitting in each one.

Teacher: “One, two, three — eyes on me! One card each... where does it LIVE?”

Every child gets one picture card — the sorting cards and the 3-part cards from the print pack — looks at it, and runs it to the right hoop. As each one lands the whole class shouts the group: **“FRUIT!” “GRAIN!”**

Collect, shuffle, hand them out again, go faster. Third round: Bigs must say the sentence before they run — **“Bread is a grain.”**

Wrong hoop is not a mistake, it is the lesson — carry it over together and say the right group twice. Nobody is ever out.

1 MIN CLOSE

Four fingers up, one per word, invisible cup for the last. Whisper → normal → shout:

Everyone: “Fruit... vegetable... grain... MILK!” (*one long glug and a moustache wipe on the shout*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *The Milk Makers* (Gail Gibbons). And leave the cold glass of water standing all day — check it together at home time. Beads all down the outside: that is dew, and it is 寒露.

3 MIN · Today's song moment — chorus → **Thursday's verse** → chorus, sung slowly.

“Milk in my cup and cheese on my plate, / strong, strong bones — doesn't that taste great?” (*pour · drink · a flat slice; strong arms, then thumbs up*)

Egg, Nuts and the Food Pyramid

Today's words: fruit · vegetable · grain · milk · egg — the whole week

Grab: an **egg** (plus a spare) and a small dish of **nuts**; every prop from the week back in the box; the five baskets; the food pyramid mat; the “My Plate” sheets (print pack page 16) and the awards (page 17).

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

The box comes out fat and heavy and clinking. Shake it very gently — today it must not be shaken hard, and they will notice.

Everyone: “What’s in the box? What’s in the box?”

Teacher: “Careful... careful...” (*lift the egg out in two cupped hands, like treasure*) “An EGG.”

Crack it on the edge of your hand into a bowl. Big gasp. “**Egg!**” Everyone cracks their own on the edge of their hand.

4 MIN TEACH · THE WHOLE PLATE, IN FIVE MOVES

Everyone stands. All five words, all five gestures, twice — slow, then fast:

Fruit! (*a huge bite*) **Vegetable!** (*pull it up out of the ground*) **Grain!** (*shake the rice jar*)

Milk! (*drink and wipe the moustache*) **Egg!** (*crack it on the edge of your hand*)

FIVE FOOD GROUPS! (*five fingers up, then one big plate drawn in the air*)

Now build the **pyramid** on the mat together: grains, vegetables and fruit along the wide bottom — *lots* of those — milk and eggs in the middle, and right at the tiny top, the cake and the sweets: *a little*.

Littles do the five moves and shout the five words. Bigs tell it back to you: “**An apple is a fruit. Corn is a grain. Milk is a dairy food.**”

Teacher fails: build the pyramid upside down — all the cake and sweets along the bottom, three sad vegetables balanced on the very top. Stand back and admire your work. Do not move until they fix it.

3 MIN GAME · PYRAMID QUICK-FIRE

“One, two, three — eyes on me!” You hold up a food — a real one or a card — they shout its group. No hands up, everyone shouts.

Teacher: “What group? ... and do we eat a LOT or a LITTLE?”

Apple → “**Fruit!**” (*thumbs up*) · Rice → “**Grain!**” (*thumbs up*) · Cheese → “**Milk!**” (*thumbs up*) · Cake → “**A little!**” (*thumbs down, everyone giggling*)

Go round twice, faster the second time, then hand the pile to a Big and let them hold the foods up for the class.

1 MIN CLOSE + PLATE FINALE

Hand out the “My Plate” sheets: every child draws one food into each part of their plate, and you scribe what they tell you. It goes home today with an award.

Everyone: “Fruit... vegetable... grain... milk... EGG! FIVE FOOD GROUPS!” (*bite · pull · shake · glug · crack · five fingers high*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *Eating the Alphabet* (Lois Ehlert) — open it anywhere, point, and let them shout the group.

3 MIN · Today's song moment — **Friday's verse**, then the **WHOLE** song, standing round the finished pyramid.

“An egg, a nut, a bit of meat, / five food groups — good to eat!” Then chorus → Mon → Tue → Wed → Thu → Fri → chorus. **That run-through is the week's review.**

★ “Five Food Groups”

C (0003)

F (2010)

G7 (0212)

Am (2000)

Strum: Down · Down · Down-Up

Am is the only new shape: one finger, second fret, top string — easier than F. It lands on “Eat them up and GROW”. If it trips you, play C there for a week; nobody will mind. The five verses are only C and G7.

CHORUS — EVERY SINGLE DAY

C Fruit and vegetables, **F** grains and **C** milk, *(count them off on your fingers)*

F Meat and eggs and **C** nuts as **G7** well! **C** *(thumb up for the fifth)*

C Five food groups up **F** on my plate to **C** day, *(draw a big round plate in the air)*

Am Eat them **F** up and **G7** GROW — hoo **C** ray! *(strong arms, then both hands high)*

MONDAY · FRUIT

C An apple is a fruit, so sweet and round,

G7 Crunch, crunch, crunch — **C** what a happy sound!

TUESDAY · VEGETABLE

C A carrot and a bean grow in the ground,

G7 Pull them up — **C** look what I found!

WEDNESDAY · GRAIN

C Rice and corn and a slice of bread,

G7 Grains, grains, grains — **C** that's what I said!

THURSDAY · MILK

C Milk in my cup and cheese on my plate,

G7 Strong, strong bones — **C** doesn't that taste great?

FRIDAY · EGG

C An egg, a nut, a bit of meat,

G7 Five food groups — **C** good to eat!

Each day: **chorus** → **today's verse** → **chorus**. Friday: sing the whole thing top to bottom, standing round the food pyramid — that run-through **is** the review of the week.